MAICON

FORWARD

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Redefining ROI: Separating Signal from Noise in the AI Search Era

Date & time: Oct. 14, 10:00-10:35 AM EST
Track: Strategic AI



Suraj Rajdev

Head of Data, Measurement & Analytics, Google

- LinkedIn

Session Description

Stop defending legacy metrics and start proving your impact in today's AI first world. In this session, we explore how to navigate an evolving landscape where consumer behavior is shifting from a keyword-driven world to a semantic search-driven world.

We'll dive into how historical KPIs and measurement approaches must adapt, moving the conversation from "tracking clicks" to "evaluating intent" through sophisticated new frameworks. You'll learn how to separate signal from noise by deploying recommendations on how to evaluate success in an era where AI-driven synthesis is the new standard.

Join us to learn how to ensure every search interaction is tracked—not just as a rank, but as a primary driver of sustainable, profitable growth in the AI Search era.

Key Quote

> *"Technology moves in dog years, and human change moves in human years."* **- Suraj Rajdev**

Session Summary

Suraj Rajdev, Head of Data, Measurement & Analytics at Google and an adjunct professor at Northwestern who teaches AI foundations and digital transformation, used his first MAICON session to challenge marketers to rethink how they define success. He opened with a lily pad exercise: if the lily pads on a pond double every day and fill it on day 60, the pond is less than 1% covered for roughly 90% of that time. His point was that humans struggle to comprehend exponential curves, and AI is an exponential technology. Citing Google's token processing, which he said reached 3.2 quadrillion in May 2026, he argued we are still in the early innings and that the next few years will bring even more change.

The core provocation was that consumer behavior has shifted materially over the past five years, and especially the past year, so any team that has not re-evaluated its KPIs in that time may not be set up for success. Rajdev said CMOs describe the moment with two words, volatility and conflating, as metrics swing unpredictably and overlapping changes make it hard to separate

signal from noise. He organized the talk around three buckets: changing consumer behavior, shifting traffic dynamics, and unit economics and monetization.

On consumer behavior, he described the move from a keyword-driven "10 blue links" world to semantic search, noting that AI Overviews has 2.5 billion monthly active users and AI Mode has surpassed a billion and is doubling every quarter. People are brainstorming more, sharing richer context, and making decisions 77% faster, which condenses the purchase journey. On traffic, he urged marketers to move beyond year-over-year dashboards toward contextual benchmarks such as click share and brand share, to recognize that not all LLM providers send the same volume or quality of traffic, and to feed first-party data into machine learning bid algorithms, which he said has driven 10 to 20% ROI improvements.

Rajdev closed with a call to build systems and processes, starting with a learning agenda reviewed roughly quarterly. His recommended metrics included informational and brand searches, net promoter score as a gauge of rising consumer expectations, quality traffic, conversion rate, and predictive lifetime value and propensity modeling. He illustrated rising expectations with a car-shopping test in which a site with an embedded LLM returned results in 17 seconds versus 54 seconds on a site with manual filters. He ended on a Peter Drucker quote: the danger in turbulent times is not the turbulence itself, but acting with yesterday's logic.

Key Takeaways

- **Benchmark against peers, not last year.** Rajdev recommends replacing year-over-year views with contextual metrics like click share and brand share, since the world changes too quickly for prior-year comparisons to show whether you are on track.
- **Treat brand share as a priority metric.** People who search for a brand are five to 10 times more likely to convert, and LLMs are blurring the line between brand and performance marketing.
- **Value quality traffic over volume.** If site traffic is down but leads and sales are roughly unchanged, the lost visitors were not converting, so engagement, time on site, and page depth matter more than raw clicks.
- **Not all AI traffic is equal.** Marketers should track the volume and quality of traffic from each LLM provider separately, because each one approaches the open web differently.
- **Feed your own data to the algorithms.** Adding first-party conversion signals to machine learning bid algorithms reduces blind spots and has driven 10 to 20% ROI improvements.
- **Build a learning agenda and experiment.** Monitor key metrics on a quarterly basis and run experiments on AI-first experiences, such as on-site chatbots, to measure their bottom-line impact on conversion.